The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Pakistan's defence minister declared "open war" on **Afghanistan** after launching "counter strikes" on Kabul and Kandahar, two Afghan cities. The attacks came in response to Afghanistan beginning "large-scale offensive operations" along the countries' border. The Taliban said their strikes were in retaliation for Pakistani attacks on Sunday. The neighbours agreed to a fragile ceasefire in October.

Paramount looked set to win the race to buy **Warner Bros Discovery**, a rival film studio, after **Netflix** declined to sweeten its bid. Netflix's shares jumped by more than 10% on the news. Warner said Paramount's improved $111bn offer was preferable to the one it had earlier accepted from Netflix, apparently ending a months-long bidding war. Regulators must clear the deal.

Britain's Green Party secured a landmark victory in a by-election in Gorton and Denton, a part of Manchester that had been held by Labour for nearly a century. Reform UK came second. Both it and the Greens, populist parties from the right and left respectively, had poured resources into the race, sensing the fragility of Labour under its unpopular prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer.

Anthropic said it could not “in good conscience” bow to the **Pentagon’s** demand to be granted unfettered access to its AI tools. The firm insists that its Claude AI must not be used for mass domestic surveillance or for autonomous weapons. Pete Hegseth, America’s war secretary, gave Anthropic until Friday to relent or risk severe sanctions, including a potential ban on Pentagon’s suppliers using Claude.

Hillary Clinton, a former American secretary of state, told a congressional committee that she had no knowledge of crimes committed by **Jeffrey Epstein** and did “not recall ever encountering” the sex offender. She ended her testimony by saying: “I want to see the truth come out.” Her husband Bill, a former president who travelled on Epstein’s jet but denies knowledge of his crimes, will testify on Friday.

Nuclear negotiations between **America** and **Iran** concluded in Geneva without a deal. Abbas Araghchi, Iran’s foreign minister, described the talks as among the “most serious” yet. The Omani mediator said “significant progress” was made. Further discussions are expected to take place next week. Iran may be playing for time: Donald Trump has suggested America will attack if it does not negotiate a deal.

A court in **Bangladesh** ordered the government to ask Interpol to issue a “red notice” against **Tulip Siddiq**, a British MP. The notice is a call for international assistance in her arrest. Bangladesh accuses Ms Siddiq of using ties to her aunt—Sheikh Hasina, Bangladesh’s autocratic former prime minister—to influence a real-estate deal. Ms Siddiq denies wrongdoing and Britain does not have an extradition treaty with Bangladesh.

Figure of the day: Less than $400m, the value of Beyond, an alternative-meat business once worth nearly $4bn. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

Is India’s economy already the world’s fourth largest?

India will publish data on economic growth during the fourth quarter on Friday. Most economists believe the annual growth rate slowed to around 7%, compared with a blistering rate of 8.2% in the previous quarter. However, they will be more interested in how a methodological change affects information about the Indian economy—and whether new figures will show that it is already the world’s fourth largest.

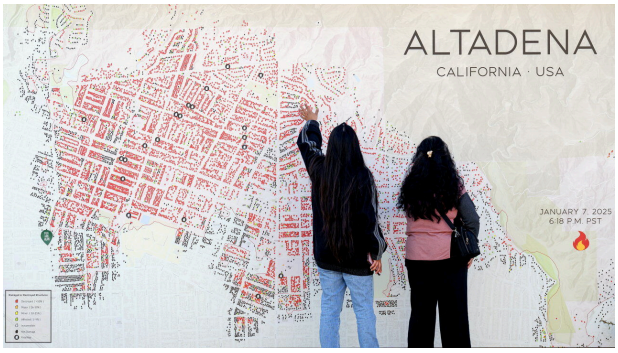
The country’s statistical agency will change the “base year” it uses to calculate GDP growth for the first time in over a decade. The idea is to capture how newer industries, such as digital services and renewable energy, have contributed to economic performance. The change will alter old GDP releases as well as the present one. In addition, the agency is using new data sources and a more detailed calculation of the effects of inflation. These changes may settle doubts about the quality of India’s data and about whether the economy’s impressive recent performance was a statistical illusion.

Photograph: Getty Images

America’s shale boom is waning

Coterra Energy, an American shale firm, reports its annual results on Friday. This month the company announced it would merge with a fellow fracker, Devon Energy, in a deal worth $58bn. The tie-up will create one of America’s largest shale-oil producers.

Yet the move reflects not the growing fortunes of fracking companies but their decline. Oil prices are roughly 10% lower now than during Joe Biden’s term, thanks to Donald Trump’s push to lower them. His tariffs on steel have pushed up the price of drilling equipment. Mid-sized shale firms such as Coterra and Devon are being forced to consolidate to stay competitive. Big firms are struggling, too. Last year the boss of Diamondback Energy said it would cut production in the Permian Basin, which sits in the epicentre of America’s shale boom. ConocoPhillips, another behemoth, recently announced plans to reduce its workforce by up to a quarter. Mr Trump’s mantra, “drill, baby, drill”, appears to be backfiring.

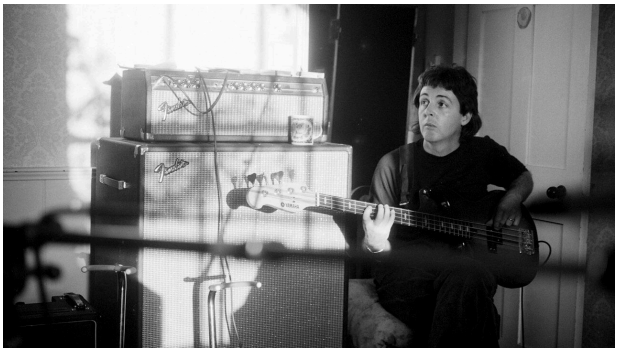


Photograph: Getty Images

Rising temperatures, rising costs

Swiss Re, one of the world's largest reinsurance firms, reports its annual results on Friday. The company's main service—insuring other insurers—is becoming increasingly crucial, and increasingly costly, as the world warms.

Swiss Re estimates that natural catastrophes were responsible for $107bn in insured losses worldwide in 2025. More than 80% of those losses were incurred in America, and half of that from a single event: the Los Angeles wildfires in January. Last year looks cheap compared with 2024, when the bill ran to $141bn. But the dip owes more to luck than to progress on combating climate change: the 2025 hurricane season was unusually quiet, with only a few major storms making landfall. In general, the costs of extreme weather are only expected to rise; it is not a coincidence that 2024 was also the hottest year on record. Gallager Re, another reinsurer, regards annual insured losses of $150bn or more as "the new normal".



Photograph: Linda McCartney

What Paul McCartney did next

“Man On The Run” tells the story of Paul McCartney’s life after The Beatles, from his first solo record to his time in a new band, Wings. Like other recent documentaries of big stars, its subject served as an executive producer. But the film is even-handed. It uses archive material to examine how Mr McCartney tried to reproduce the camaraderie and sense of equality that nourished his previous band in its early days.

That proved difficult given Mr McCartney’s superstar status by the time he set up Wings. Still, the success of the band, which went from playing impromptu university gigs in 1972 to becoming a polished arena-rock act four years later, is down to the singer-songwriter’s apparent grit as well as his celebrity. Unable to enjoy his fame and struggling with post-Beatles depression, he started from scratch. Watching that journey is as enjoyable as the music.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Who wrote "An Inconvenient Truth", a book about climate change?

Thursday: Which prominent scientist, who helped explain that sickle cell anemia was caused by an abnormal protein, became an advocate for taking high doses of vitamin C?

If you want a new idea, read an old book.

Ivan Pavlov